

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Circumcision

Understanding the procedure, benefits, risks, and aftercare for your newborn

WHAT IS CIRCUMCISION?

Circumcision is the surgical removal of the foreskin — the fold of skin covering the tip (glans) of the penis. It is one of the most commonly performed surgical procedures in the U.S., with approximately **60% of newborn males** circumcised. The AAP states the benefits outweigh risks, but the decision is personal.

THE PROCEDURE

- Performed in the hospital within 24–48 hrs of birth
- Local anesthesia (dorsal penile nerve block) is used
- Three common techniques: Gomco clamp, Plastibell, Mogen clamp
- Takes 5–15 minutes
- Healing takes 7–10 days
- Sugar pacifier offered for comfort during procedure

BENEFITS VS. RISKS — AAP POSITION

✓ Potential Benefits

- Lower risk of urinary tract infections (UTIs)
- Lower risk of penile cancer (rare)
- Reduced risk of some STIs (HIV, HPV, herpes)
- Prevents phimosis (tight foreskin)
- Easier genital hygiene

⚠ Potential Risks

- Bleeding (most common complication, 1–2%)
- Infection (rare with proper care)
- Meatal stenosis (narrowing of urethral opening)
- Unsatisfactory cosmetic result
- Severe complications very rare (<0.2%)

AFTERCARE INSTRUCTIONS

- Apply petrolatum (Vaseline) with each diaper change
- Gently clean with warm water at each diaper change
- Avoid soap on healing area for first week
- If Plastibell used, ring falls off in 5–10 days
- Yellow film (normal healing) — do not remove
- Avoid wipes with fragrance/alcohol until healed

WHO SHOULD NOT BE CIRCUMCISED

- Premature or unstable newborns
- Hypospadias (urethral opening not at tip)
- Chordee or other penile abnormalities
- Family history of bleeding disorders
- Ambiguous genitalia
- Always deferred until baby is stable and healthy

⚠ CALL YOUR DOCTOR IF YOU NOTICE

- ⚠ Active bleeding that doesn't stop with pressure
- ⚠ Swelling, redness, or pus at the site
- ⚠ Fever over 100.4°F in the newborn
- ⚠ Baby not urinating within 6–8 hours after procedure
- ⚠ Yellow-green discharge (not normal yellow film)
- ⚠ Foul odor from the circumcision site
- ⚠ Plastibell ring still in place after 10 days
- ⚠ Extreme pain or prolonged crying after first day

♥ You Are Making the Best Choice for Your Family

The decision to circumcise is personal and involves cultural, religious, and medical considerations. There is no universally right answer. Whatever you decide, your baby will be cared for with skill and compassion. If you proceed with circumcision, the procedure is safe, quick, and well-tolerated by newborns.